

Reflective practice

Reflective practice is learning through examining what we think happened on any occasion, and how we think others perceived the event and us, opening our practice to scrutiny by others

Bolton (2010, p.13)

The experiential learning cycle developed by David Kolb suggests how we learn from experience, and highlights the role of reflection in this process. This representation of the process is from Kolb and Kolb (2005):

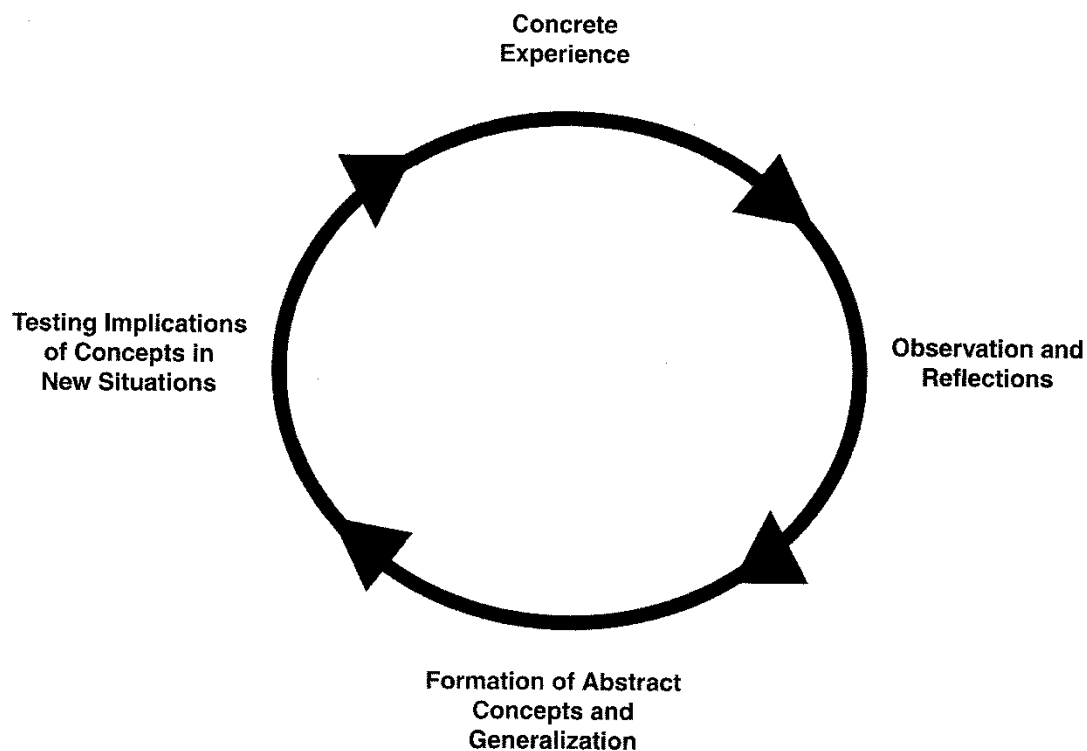


Figure 1. The experiential learning cycle

Donald Schon (1983) suggested there are three types of reflective practice: reflection-on-action, reflection-in-action and reflection-for-action

Reflection-on-action is retrospective and has four stages:

- Re-inhabit (relive the experience)
- Reflect (notice what was going on)
- Review (critically analyse the situation)
- Reframe (capture new understanding).

Reflection-in-action is a process of reviewing and reflecting on experiences as they are being undertaken. Arguably, it is also retrospective, but concerns things that have only very recently occurred, and which are part of an activity that is still going on as we reflect.

Reflection-for-action, combines insight with intention to apply learning in professional life.

Most reflective thinking models tend to involve three fundamental processes:

- retrospection - thinking back about a situation or experience
- self-evaluation - critically analysing and evaluating the actions and feelings associated with the experience from different perspectives
- reorientation - using the results of self-evaluation to influence future approaches to similar situations or experiences

Gibbs (1988) elaborated on Kolb's cycle, and posed a set of questions that we might use to structure a written reflection on an experience:



Figure 2 Gibbs' (1988) Reflective Cycle

G Bolton (2010) *Reflective Practice*, Sage

G Gibbs (1988) *Learning by Doing: A guide to teaching and learning methods*. Further Education Unit. Oxford Polytechnic: Oxford

Kolb, A.Y. and Kolb, D.A. 2005. *The Kolb Learning Style Inventory—Version 3.1 2005 Technical Specifications*, Hay Group.

D Schon (1983) *The Reflective Practitioner, How Professionals Think In Action*, Basic Books